

CORONA AUSTRALIS

THE SOUTHERN CROWN

ONE OF THE SMALLEST CONSTELLATIONS, CORONA AUSTRALIS IS ALSO ONE OF THE ORIGINAL 48 GREEK CONSTELLATIONS, ALTHOUGH IT IS NOT ASSOCIATED WITH ANY PARTICULAR MYTH.

The pattern of the crown of Corona Australis is not golden and jewel-studded like the Northern Crown, Corona Borealis, but a wreath of leaves. Other cultures saw the stars differently. To the ancient Chinese, its stars represented a turtle, while indigenous Australians saw a boomerang or a coolamon (a shallow dish).

None of the constellation's stars is particularly bright but the curved shape they form makes the constellation easy to spot. Its two brightest stars, Alpha and Beta, appear indistinguishable but are very different. Beta is the bigger and more luminous—although almost four times farther away than Alpha, it shines with the same brightness in our sky. In the north of the constellation a huge region of nebulosity includes NGC 6729, one of the closest star-forming nebulae to us, lying about 400 light-years away.



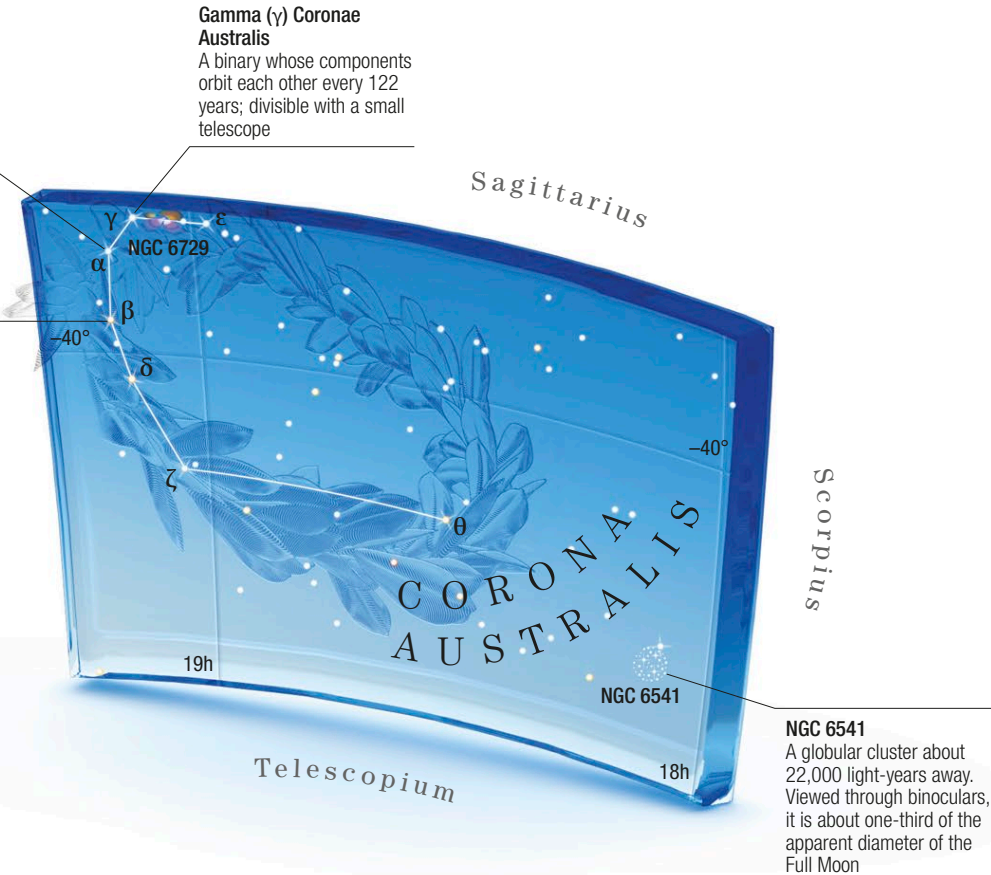
△ Coronet Cluster
This infrared and X-ray image shows young stars in the Coronet Cluster. Located near NGC 6729 and about 420 light-years away, the cluster is one of the nearest and most active regions of star-birth.

◁ NGC 6729
The youngest stars in this nebula are hidden inside dense gas and dust clouds. These young stars are throwing off high-speed jets of material that create shock-waves in the gas and cause it to shine.

Alpha (α) Corone Australis
A main-sequence star like the Sun but white, more than twice the Sun's size, and 31 times as luminous

Gamma (γ) Corone Australis
A binary whose components orbit each other every 122 years; divisible with a small telescope

Beta (β) Corone Australis
A giant star 43 times the size of the Sun and 730 times more luminous. It is 13 times more luminous than Alpha but the same brightness in the sky due to its greater distance



KEY DATA

- Size ranking** 80
- Brightest stars** Alpha (α) 4.1, Beta (β) 4.1
- Genitive** Corone Australis
- Abbreviation** CrA
- Highest in sky at 10pm** July–August
- Fully visible** 44°N–90°S

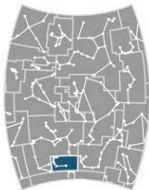


CHART 4

MAIN STARS

- Alpha (α) Corone Australis**
White main-sequence star
☼ 4.1 ↔ 125 light-years
- Beta (β) Corone Australis**
Yellow giant
☼ 4.1 ↔ 475 light-years

DEEP-SKY OBJECTS

- NGC 6541**
Globular cluster
- NGC 6729**
Star-forming nebula
- Coronet Cluster**
Open cluster